

We Just Want Order

*Political and Social Imaginaries of the Far-Right in Italy
and France*

Research project

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Ideological Trends in France and Italy

The populist radical right has gained increasing support across Europe in recent years, with Italy and France offering two prominent examples. This rise in popularity is reflected in the 2022 elections: Italy's right-wing bloc won a record share of legislative votes, while France's extreme-right (Rassemblement National and similar parties) achieved its highest first-round presidential result in recent history¹. This development reflects deeper shifts in values and beliefs. Over the past two decades, sociological research has examined the structural causes and long-term foundations of this transformation. Yet systematic cross-national comparison remains limited.

To explore these dynamics, this project focuses on political imaginaries – collective structures that organize the imagination and symbolism of politics, shaping how political meanings and institutions are perceived (Browne, 2021). This framework is best examined through cross-national comparison. France and Italy constitute a theoretically relevant pair: both show strong radical-right electoral consolidation, but they differ in historical, institutional, and cultural trajectories.

While the rise of the extreme right has been widely documented, existing research often emphasizes broad European trends or single-variable explanations, leaving national variation and the relational structuring of values underexplored. Determining whether these imaginaries converge or diverge therefore carries broader theoretical implications: convergence would support arguments about a transnational cultural backlash, whereas divergence would highlight the continued importance of national political cultures. Multiple Correspondence Analysis (MCA) enables us to identify how extreme-right values cluster into coherent dimensions and how these

¹ In Italy, the center-right coalition won 43.79% of the vote in the 2022 legislative elections, compared to 26.13% for the center-left (Sky TG24). In France, Marine Le Pen obtained 23.15% of the vote in the first round of the 2022 presidential election, against 27.84% for Emmanuel Macron (France Télévisions).

configurations differ across national contexts. The findings contribute to debates on European political homogenization versus persistent national specificity.

Ideas, Values, and Political Actors: What Does Literature Say?

Delage (2021) shows that right-leaning self-placement has increased in recent years, with younger generations now among the most likely to position themselves on the right, challenging the traditional association between right-wing self-placement and older voters. In parallel, political, economic, health, and migration crises have contributed to the consolidation of spaces favorable to radical-right attitudes (Ivaldi, 2022; Masu, 2024).

Such shifts can be understood through the lens of cultural backlash: as Arzheimer (2011) argues, rapid social and political change often triggers reactions aimed at defending established cultural and moral norms. These reactions can reinforce attachment to tradition, religious orientations, and restrictive attitudes toward immigration.

Within this value framework, religiosity plays a central role in structuring moral and cultural beliefs, shaping norms around family and gender (Bréchon, 2006). Beyond religiosity, adherence to traditional values constitutes a broader pillar of right-leaning orientations, encompassing norms related to family, gender roles, and cultural continuity (Bréchon, 2019).

Immigration has become central to radical-right imaginaries, particularly following the 2015 migration crisis, which intensified perceptions of cultural threat and reinforced far-right support in France and Italy (Delage, 2021; Brentel, 2025).

While some trends are shared across countries, the radical right manifests differently depending on the national context. In France, it has undergone a process of ‘de-demonization’ under Marine Le Pen, aiming

to normalize the *Rassemblement National* through discursive moderation, media repositioning, and distancing from past extremist associations (Masu, 2023). In Italy, by contrast, the right has been reconfigured through the consolidation of a national-conservative movement, facilitated by the weakening of traditional parties after the *Mani Pulite*² scandals and the Berlusconi³ years. This shift is exemplified by *Fratelli d'Italia*, which presents itself as a disciplined party rooted in cultural conservatism and national identity (Masu, 2023).

This project therefore adopts an exploratory, descriptive approach, using quantitative tools to map extreme-right value imaginaries rather than provide a causal account of voting behavior.

Extreme-Right Imaginaries: A Comparative Perspective

While much research explains the socio-economic drivers of far-right support, fewer studies examine the symbolic and value-based imaginaries through which these voters interpret the social world, particularly in a comparative perspective.

This gap in the literature suggests the need to shift attention away from why individuals support the extreme right, and toward how they perceive the social world through their values. From a comparative perspective, our study aims to identify the shared and divergent configurations that structure these imaginaries in France and Italy. We ask whether extreme-right supporters in both countries share a common set of representations, or whether these imaginaries remain shaped by distinct national contexts.

How are extreme-right political imaginaries expressed in France and Italy?

² *Mani Pulite* refers to a series of judicial investigations in the early 1990s that exposed widespread corruption and illegal party financing among Italian political and economic elites.

³ *Silvio Berlusconi* was an Italian politician who served three terms as Prime Minister and founded the center-right party *Forza Italia*, playing a key role in reshaping Italian conservative politics.

Research Expectations

We assume that far-right political imaginaries in France and Italy revolve around the defense of national and cultural identity, but manifest differently according to each country's cultural and historical context. Existing sociological research highlights the importance of tradition and national sentiment (Ivaldi, 2022; Canzano Giansante, 2023). National identity becomes a key reference point in response to perceived threats related to the economy, migration, and globalization. In empirical terms, these political imaginaries are approached through individuals' values and attitudes toward nationhood, tradition, and perceived societal threats. Based on the literature on extreme-right political imaginaries and the values structuring them, we formulate three hypotheses concerning the principal dimensions of such imaginaries in France and Italy.

H1: We expect opposition to immigration to structure one of the principal dimensions of extreme-right imaginaries in both France and Italy.

Migration is one of the central issues in the far-right imaginary, frequently framed not only as a demographic or economic challenge, but as a symbolic threat to national identity and cultural continuity (Delage, 2021). In this sense, debates around migration reflect broader value-based anxieties. Drawing on the cultural backlash thesis (Arzheimer, 2011; Masu, 2024), such attitudes can be understood as reactions to rapid social change perceived as destabilizing established cultural frameworks.

H2: We expect adherence to traditional values to structure a distinct dimension of extreme-right imaginaries in both countries.

In both France and Italy, traditional values, such as family, gender roles, and inherited cultural norms, remain central to right-leaning belief systems (Donà, 2022; Masu, 2024). We therefore expect adherence to these values to be an important component of extreme-right imaginaries.

H3: We expect the role of religion in structuring extreme-right imaginaries to differ between France and Italy.

In Italy, religion and Catholic tradition remain important symbolic reference points in political mobilization (Donà, 2022; Masu, 2024). In France, by contrast, identity references are less structured around religion and instead center on secularism, emphasizing the Republic, cultural heritage and national identity (Brentel, 2025). We therefore expect religion to carry different weights in structuring extreme-right imaginaries across the two national contexts.

Mapping Values: Methodology

Empirically, this study uses the eleventh wave of the European Social Survey (ESS, 2023), which collects data on attitudes, beliefs, and behaviors across European countries. Its values-oriented questions provide a rich empirical basis for analyzing extreme-right value systems and allow for cross-national comparison.

We first filtered the sample to French and Italian respondents, and then used a left–right scale to measure respondents’ ideological self-placement. This scale is widely used and considered one of the most relevant measures of political orientation (Aybar, 2024), allowing us to identify individuals who locate themselves at the extreme right of the ideological spectrum. Respondents who place themselves at 9 or 10 are retained, following recent research to capture the most radical ideological positions (Ramos, 2024). The final subsample consists of 229

respondents, including 126 in Italy and 103 in France, representing approximately 5% of all French and Italian respondents in the ESS.

We use Multiple Correspondence Analysis (MCA), a multivariate dimensionality-reduction technique. MCA identifies the main dimensions structuring values and attitudes by projecting individuals and categories into a low-dimensional space (Alecú, 2022). This approach visualizes how key values cluster among extreme-right respondents and allows comparison across national contexts.

We distinguish between two types of variables: active variables, which define the dimensions of the analysis and are directly linked to our hypotheses, and supplementary variables, which are projected onto the MCA space after the analysis to interpret patterns.

To conduct this research, we will first assess the internal consistency of the selected active variables for each hypothesis using Cronbach's alpha, removing any items that do not contribute coherently to their respective construct. We will then run the MCA, highlighting variables according to the value dimension they measure to facilitate interpretation. To further explore the empirical structure of extreme-right imaginaries, we will apply an unsupervised machine learning approach, clustering respondents based on their MCA coordinates. This method identifies subgroups of individuals with similar combinations of attitudes without relying on pre-labeled outcomes. We expect two clusters aligned by nationality, both opposing immigration and valuing tradition but differing in religious versus secular-national orientations.

Next, supplementary variables will be projected onto the MCA space to assess whether socio-demographic and political characteristics are systematically associated with positions along the main dimensions. The country variable will be included in order to compare extreme-right imaginaries across France and Italy and test the third hypothesis. Age cohorts will also be explored to examine whether younger generations

share similar value-based imaginaries with older respondents. Inspired by Delage (2021), age cohorts are defined in broader categories to maintain sufficient group sizes for comparative analysis (≤ 34 , 35–49, 50–64, ≥ 65). Political party affiliation is included to capture intra-extreme-right heterogeneity, and analysis will be restricted to parties with at least 15 respondents: Fratelli d'Italia, Lega, Forza Italia (Italy), and Rassemblement National (France).

To analyze the supplementary variables, we will use supervised machine learning via elastic net regressions, which perform variable selection and regularization, useful given the small number of predictors and potential multicollinearity between party, age, and country. This approach will assess how each supplementary variable predicts respondents' positions along the MCA dimensions. For this analysis, the country variable will be dichotomized, age cohorts coded as an ordinal scale, and political party included as dummy variables, with regression coefficients indicating the relative importance and direction of each variable.

Several limitations of this approach should be acknowledged. First, this study selects respondents based on the left–right self-placement scale (9–10), which may exclude moderately right-leaning individuals who share similar value structures and does not directly reflect actual voting behavior. Consequently, the final sample is relatively small, which may limit the stability of multivariate analyses such as MCA. The sample size could be increased in future work by expanding the inclusion criteria to respondents who place themselves at 8 on the left–right scale. Finally, although the ESS provides a rich dataset, the limited number of items related to our thematic focus may not capture all relevant dimensions of extreme-right imaginaries.

We expect this analysis to reveal key dimensions of far-right imaginaries in both France and Italy, with migration and traditional values forming central axes. Religion is likely to play a stronger role in

Italy, while secular-national identity shapes the French context, reflecting nation-specific patterns. The findings will offer a concise comparative mapping of extreme-right value systems and insights into how these imaginaries converge and diverge across national contexts.

Future research could expand the sample to respondents scoring 8–10 on the left–right scale, conduct longitudinal comparisons across ESS waves, and include additional supplementary variables such as education or occupation to further examine socio-demographic heterogeneity.

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